

Living on air



Tillandsia
air plant

Silvery leaves hang in chains.



Spanish moss

Bristly moss produces spores that can grow into new moss plants.



Orthotrichum moss

These stiff leaves are specially adapted to absorb moisture from the air.



Bird's nest fern

The undivided fronds grow up to 59 in (150 cm) in length.



Fissidens moss

Dense cushions of this moss grow in shady, damp areas.

Forked fronds like a deer's antlers give this plant its name.



Staghorn fern

Not all plants grow in soil. Some, known as epiphytes, anchor themselves onto other plants or tree trunks instead. These plants do not take nutrients from their hosts, however; they absorb water and nutrients from the air and rain, or sometimes from the dead leaves that collect around their base.

Mosses such as **fissidens moss** or **orthotrichum moss** can often be seen growing on walls or tree trunks. These tiny plants survive by storing water like a sponge. They then use this water to make food. **Spanish moss** is not really a moss at all, but a flowering plant. It is one of about